



Renewed, Not Redeemed

A Two-Hall Comparison of an Opt-Out Meal-Plan Default Against Actual Redemption

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Background

One dining hall auto-renews its meal plan each term unless a student opts out; a second still requires active reconfirmation. The Living Dashboard reports both near capacity. Does either figure describe what gets eaten?

Aims

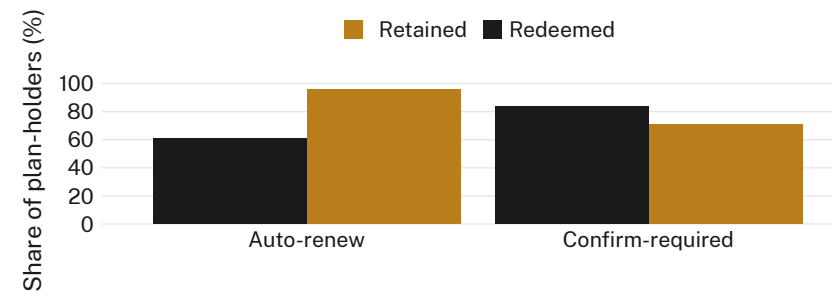
- Compare term-on-term plan retention between an opt-out hall and a confirm-required hall.
- Match retention against redemption — the share of paid meal swipes actually collected.
- Test whether the retention indicator moves with attendance, or only with the form.

Methods

- 2 dining halls (1 auto-renew, 1 confirm-required) · swipe-card redemption logs · one full term, Feb-Jun 2026
- n = 612 auto-renew plan-holders vs n = 340 confirm-required plan-holders
- Hall assignment and redemption thresholds pre-registered; no reallocation mid-term

Results

Retention held at 96% in the auto-renew hall against 71% in the confirm-required hall; redemption ran the opposite order, at 61% against 84% of paid meals collected.



Auto-renew hall retention held at 96% against 71% for the confirm-required hall over the Feb-Jun 2026 term (n = 952), while redemption inverted: 61% of paid meals collected at the auto-renew hall against 84% at the confirm-required hall.

Discussion & conclusions

Retention counts a card not yet cancelled; redemption counts a tray collected. The auto-renew default appears to manufacture the gap it is credited for closing — raising the indicator while lowering redemption per head, a distinction the Living Dashboard's single retention tile does not carry. Next: pair the retention tile with a redemption-weighted measure before the default rolls out campus-wide.

References

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De-identified swipe-card redemption logs only; no student names retained; hall assignment and redemption thresholds pre-registered.

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“Retention held; nobody checked what was eaten.”

The auto-renew hall kept 96% of plan-holders enrolled through the Feb-Jun 2026 term, against 71% at the confirm-required hall.